

2026 FALL SCREENS GUIDE

A look ahead to what's coming in movies, television and streaming, including Sorkin's Facebook follow-up and a new Poehler comedy

WINNER OF 29 PULITZER PRIZES FOR EXCELLENCE IN JOURNALISM

Final

Chicago Tribune



\$5.75 | SUNDAY, AUGUST 30, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



The hot corner

ONE WRIGLEYVILLE SPOT HANGS ON TO ITS ROOTS
AND BALLHAWKS AS THE CUBS MARK THEIR 150TH ANNIVERSARY

By Andrew Carter | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

On the last day of June, the flags danced in a stiff wind above Wrigley Field and Moe Mullins arrived more than three hours before first pitch, just like usual. He set up his camping chair under the ash tree at the corner of Waveland and Kenmore, across the street from the back of the left field bleachers, and the neighborhood slowly came to life.

In time, the street vendors appeared and the merchandise stands opened and the patio at Murphy's, a block away, started to fill in. Soon, the spectators gathered along the brick wall and waited for the bleacher gates to open. For a while, though, it was quiet, and the last refuge of old Wrigley, and its old neighborhood, belonged to Mullins.

He is the unofficial mayor of Waveland and Kenmore avenues, the elder statesman among the characters who give it character. The Chicago Cubs this weekend are celebrating their 150th anniversary as a National League member. They've spent 110 of those years at Wrigley, where the corner just beyond left field remains old-school, a small throwback in the middle of ever-expanding change.

The Cubs have bought up many of the nearby buildings. The rooftops are a little less organically charming and a lot more expensive. Trendy bars and restaurants have moved in all over. Even Wrigley's iconic marquee comes with a corporate sponsor, and has for more than a decade.

The corner, though, remains the corner. Lawn chairs. Lifers. Good banter, some of which is even suitable for children. The most prominent ad there is handwritten, for the Gatorade that Dave Davison sells out of a cooler: \$3 for Cubs fans and \$4 for Cards fans, with the \$5 for White Sox fans crossed out and replaced with "stay thirsty."

Davison, like Mullins, has been on the corner for a long time. It's home to an eclectic collection of oddballs, super fans, ballhawks, townies, Cubs workers, dog walkers (free treats) and the occasional and keen-eyed, curious tourist, who can sense good company when they

See **CORNER** on Page A4

Above: Moe Mullins tosses a baseball as he and Mary Ellen Gourley hang out at corner of Waveland and Kenmore avenues outside Wrigley Field before the Cubs host the White Sox on Aug. 17. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

SPECIAL REPORT

'That's taxpayer money'

Illinois ignores rules and red flags as 'servant leader' runs up \$100M state tab, then closes 2 hospitals

By Joe Mahr and Lisa Schencker
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In a region already struggling to keep hospitals open, the Chicago area was at risk of losing two more — during a pandemic — when Dr. Manoj Prasad convinced state officials he was just the man to save them.

Prasad said he'd spent decades as a "servant leader" fixing struggling hospitals and clinics. He could trim budgets. Boost staff morale. Maintain quality care. And he had found a partner willing to finance it all.

All Prasad needed was for the state Health Facilities and Services Review Board to allow him and his business partner to buy West Suburban Medical Center and Weiss Memorial Hospital, both owned by the same company. The board gave them the green light.

Over the next several years, the hospitals received more than \$24 million in state grants while racking up debts of roughly \$100 million in state loans and unpaid taxes. Then they closed, eliminating more than 400 beds, erasing roughly 1,400 jobs and cutting neighborhood residents off from valuable medical care.

Along the way, state officials missed red flags while failing to follow rules designed to prevent something like this from happening, a Tribune investigation has found.

Records suggest the health facilities review board did little to vet Prasad and his partner before agreeing to let them take over the hospitals in Oak Park and Uptown in 2022. Then, when Prasad resurfaced with pleas for taxpayer dollars, the Department of Healthcare and Family Services handed over tens of millions in loans while doing little to track how the money was being spent.

The hospitals also received state grants from another agency, the Illinois Department of Public Health, that required them to submit third-party audits under a state law meant to ensure tax dollars are spent responsibly. There is no record of the state receiving any such audits, yet the department kept sending cash — even as its own inspectors documented the hospital buildings' deterioration.

Meanwhile, the for-profit firm operating the hospitals, led by Prasad, broke

See **HOSPITALS** on Page A12

INSIDE



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

History of his own

Pete Crow-Armstrong crashed the Cubs' 150th anniversary party at Wrigley Field on Saturday with three home runs in front of a who's who of all-time franchise greats. **Sports**

War emboldens Iran

After six months of war, Iran's leadership has coalesced around a hard core of military generals and clerics who are ready for a long confrontation with the U.S. **Nation & World, Page B5**

Solutions elusive for a 'rapid kill' soybean disease

Little known about fungus found at Pike County farm

By Finnegan Belleau
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Reagan Hoskin considers herself a rule follower by nature.

After graduating high school in 2018, she spent the summer monitoring crops for her father, carrying out his instructions to a T: Zigzag along soybean fields. Scan the crops at vantage points. Note anything that looks out of place.

Then one day, at the very edge of the family's Pike County farm in western Illinois, she spotted a patch of yellow plants.

"I'm like, 'Aw man, the rest of the field had looked fine,'" Hoskin said. "Now I'm gonna have to actually walk down there and look at it."

She previously learned how to identify soybean diseases and suspected this was sudden death syndrome, a severe but manageable ailment.

See **DISEASE** on Page A10

Ron Hoskin, an attorney and farmer, sits on a tank at his farm on Aug. 13 in Pittsfield, Illinois. Hoskin's daughter, Reagan Hoskin, was the first to discover red crown rot while out surveying the family's soybean fields in 2018. Hoskin and surrounding farmers are frustrated by the spread of the fungus since then. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 86 L: 73
MON. H: 90 L: 73
TUE. H: 94 L: 75
FULL WEATHER REPORT B12

INDEX

Almanac A15
Crossword ... In Comics
Editorials B1

Horoscope ... In Comics
Letters B3
Obituaries A16

Rides G7
Success G4
Television E7

179th year No. 242
© Chicago Tribune